

2.3.7 Reveal

Take the time and have the patience to explain what's on screen, if it consists of figures and numbers and any other data that's not all that obvious. If it were obvious, why is it on the slide? And if it's not obvious, how can you neglect to explain it?

Terms need to be defined. Data needs to be interpreted. Even things like what's on the X and Y axes in a graph might sometimes need to be explained. Don't assume things of the audience—give them the benefit of doubt, as it were.

Attend one really shoddy presentation and you'll see the importance of this. The speaker switches to a slide with two charts on it, says merely, "So this is how we're positioned; like I was saying, we intend on changing this," and advances to the next slide. Sound familiar?

2.3.8 End

When the end of the show approaches, give out signals to that effect. Just as the audience doesn't like to be faced with a slide they didn't expect, they also don't want to be faced with an abrupt ending. This is not just a matter of courtesy—it's also about aiding the thought process. When one knows the show is going to end, one begins summarising (internally) what was said, and formulates questions.

Coming to that, any presentation should lead to a discussion. You do know there will be a question-and-answer session after the presentation, but the slideshow should *lead up to* the discussion. Formulate questions beforehand and ask them; take all questions and answer them. Switch on your slides again if they will serve a purpose.

And to end *this* chapter, we'll just remind you that you should round off a presentation by offering the slides as handouts if anyone wants them, and finally thanking the audience for their time and attention.

Thank you.